Grasping Straws?

an original deck of lateral-thinking prompts, print-and-play edition

1. Print at 100% (“actual size”), not “fit to page”: the cards are the true size of the manufactured deck, 2.5 × 3.5 inches, 9 to a sheet.
2. Print pages 2–8 single-sided, on the heaviest stock your printer accepts.
3. Optional backs: put the printed sheets back in and print the last page on the reverse of each (long-edge flip).
4. Cut along the lines. A ruler and a blade beat scissors.
5. Shuffle. The 5 rules cards at the end are ways to play; the deck doesn’t negotiate.

This free edition is for your own studio. The manufactured deck, on real card stock and shuffled by your own hands, is the instrument; straws.lscaturchio.xyz has the details, the whole deck to read, and a card a day. Card texts © the deck’s author.



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01

Solve the wrong problem beautifully.

02

Remove the part you rehearsed.

03

Give the smallest part the most room.

04

Halve it.

Then halve the half.

05

Keep the bridge.

Cut both banks.

06

Let the accident audition.

07

Give the mistake a name and a job.

08

Which rule are you obeying without being asked?

09

Trade your best idea for your strangest one.

10

Stay with the boring part longer than is polite.

11

Copy the structure; betray the content.

12

End earlier than feels safe.

13

Break the pattern one step before it completes.

14

Describe it to someone who cannot see it.

Build what you said.

15

Make it hospitable to strangers.

16

What would this be at four in the morning?

17

Finish it badly, then defend the flaw.

18

Which part would you keep if you had to pay for each one?

19

Tune to the room, not the chart.

20

Play the chord you can’t name.

21

Voice it in two notes.

22

Detune one string; keep the fingering.

23

Let the drums lie about the tempo.

24

Play only what rings after the note.

25

Treat the amp as the instrument.

26

Record the rehearsal. Discard the take.

27

What is the
silence doing?

28

Turn one
element to zero.

Notice what remains.

29

Hold the shot
until it confesses.

30

Weather is
a character.

Cast it.

31

Cut on the breath,
not the action.

32

Let the location
rewrite the scene.

33

Show the aftermath;
imply the event.

34

Water, smoke,
or dust: choose
one witness.

35

Light it for the
room it used to be.

36

The frame is a door.

Which way
does it open?

37

Write the
footnote first.

38

Steal the syntax
of a prayer.

39

Say it once.

Trust the echo.

40

Translate it into
plain speech;
keep the ghost.

41

Delete every sentence
you're proud of.

Read what's left.

42

Let a minor
character narrate.

43

Name what is
guarding this.

Ask what it wants.

44

Descend,
retrieve, return.

Which step are
you skipping?

45

Give the work ten minutes that ask for nothing back.

46

What is the plain old word for this: song, map, letter, joke?

47

Consult the dream, then disobey it.

48

Cross the threshold facing backward.

49

Answer the question the reader is too polite to ask.

50

Read it aloud.

Rewrite where your breath runs out.

51

Close it for a night.

Rebuild only what you remember.

52

What has to stay outside for you to go in?

HOW TO PLAY

TEN MINUTES

solo

Draw one card. Obey it for ten minutes, literally, not approximately. No second draw. Keep the result or throw it away, but look at it first.

HOW TO PLAY

THREE STRAWS

solo

Deal three cards face down. Turn them in order: what is actually wrong; how to work on it; when to stop. Write the third one down.

HOW TO PLAY

FIRST & LAST

solo · one session

Draw before you begin and work under the card. When you believe you're done, draw exactly one more and let it edit the ending.

HOW TO PLAY

BLIND JURY

3 or more

One card for everyone, read aloud. No one says how they read it. Twenty minutes of work, then show the results side by side. Steal the best direction.

HOW TO PLAY

EXQUISITE RELAY

2 · over days or weeks

One piece, passed back and forth. Each pass begins with a secret draw. When the piece is finished, reveal the cards in order and title it with one.



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